

Roundtable Discussion**Luke 1: 39-56****Group Description**

My group members included men who volunteered to discuss the scripture with me on Thursday night the 7th at Room in the Inn at Vine Street Christian Church (Disciples of Christ). They arrived in a van driven by a volunteer a little after 6:30 pm, coming in from cold rain, traffic, and, for many of them, a long day's work. After getting settled on beds arranged in the open around the fellowship hall, turning the tv to the football game, and/or looking over some of the goods labeled "not wanted" (by anyone else, apparently) that were up for grabs, Lydia from Vine Street told us about dinner and introduced me to pray and explain my open but not obligatory offer to discuss the scripture for my sermon. Some of the men sat at the table where I'd placed my things once we got plates of food, and some wandered by or chimed in from an adjacent table to join pieces of the conversation as the night continued. We occasionally paused to hear instructions and an offer for dessert from Lydia. We read the scripture aloud several times as individuals joined in. All in all, some of us chatted for approximately 1.5 hours. The names below are pseudonyms as I forgot to ask for permission to use their names.

- Nick seemed eager to discuss the text and sat down by me at the dinner table first thing. We'd had a brief conversation before, where he'd told me he never thought he'd end up where he is, and that just a year ago, he'd been in a home and had a job. He works in IT—"I'm the IT guy," he said—but is struggling to find a job right now. He's got one possible option coming up, but he said with so many people applying for it at this bigger company, he has no idea if he'll get it.
- Jim is a veteran who seems to have spent a good deal of time studying the biblical text and the history of Christianity. He has a prosthetic leg, and uses a cane when he walks. He took a few laps around the area after our conversation as a way to stretch and converse with others. He referred several times to some of his military missions, experiences, and companions.
- Ben came in and out of the conversation as he wandered to follow the football game on TV as well. He focused on the movement of the Holy Spirit and hopefulness of the passage.
- Joe joined in later in our conversation, and commented on the hopefulness and the incarnation.
- Barry wandered in for a period in the middle of the conversation, commenting on the Spirit in the passage and how we need to follow God's word throughout the bible.
- Ted, a member of Vine Street and volunteer present to help set up and for the meal, discussed the role of religion and what to make of the present state of the world—which he believes to be more problematic than he's ever seen. He was curious why I'd chosen this scripture, particularly in relation to what he saw in the world. He also asked Nick about what some of the other shelters in town are like, and was surprised when Nick said at one downtown, much of the staff and/or volunteers talk down to the men present for help, acting as though they are stupid and beneath them. He also described the poor condition of the showers (someone from the table next to us chimed in to say that you just don't want to take a shower there), where the water is always either freezing cold or blistering hot.

Verbatim

A song of hope + the power of God and the Holy Spirit mentioned by Nick, Ben, Barry, Joe, Ted.

- Nick focused on the hopefulness of Mary's Magnificat immediately. Ben and Barry talked about how this was a song of praise of God's promises and faithfulness, saying that praise was the only right response and mentioning the Holy Spirit's role in bringing forth Mary's words.
- Joe said the passage was hopeful especially for people "like us" (referring to himself and the men experiencing homelessness).
- Ben focused on the hope being for the spiritual world rather than the material one, when I asked what we were to make of the continuing existence of poverty and disparities of power and resources.

The incarnation

- When I asked where we might find Jesus being born today, Joe remarked, with a touch of awe, that Jesus was born to "someone like us," and would be with *them* today.
- Jim discussed the Roman soldier who became a follower of Jesus because he experienced his divinity at the crucifixion. He also mentioned several times that Jesus was born to a "lowly" carpenter, not so different than a carpenter today.

Faithful following

- Jim talked about times he's wondered about a question of faith and an answer has arrived either unexpectedly or through research and study. He said that sometimes you have to have patience if you don't have an answer yet: it may come.
- Barry commented on the importance of following God's word as described in the bible, and gestured at the question of what to do in response to people we see not following it.

Giving generously

- Jim told us about a family he's connected with in Asia, whom he plans to visit. He bought cell phones for the children in the family for their birthdays.

The heart of religion/religions

- Nick and Ted discussed how all religions could potentially get behind the message of justice that Mary's Magnificat portrays.

On the Way to the Sermon (I have many questions...)

- How can Christians be truly in solidarity with people who are without housing and be in respectful conversation with them?
- Considering that Christmas is coming up, and cold days and nights are ahead and will impact people without shelter especially. What does it mean to do Christmas faithfully? To experience joy as a person who is poor and oppressed, and as a person who has more societal privilege and access to resources. How might this scripture be heard by the different groups?
 - In a charity environment where the church offers items that are "not wanted" and are yet also surprised at some of the degrading treatment the men experience at other shelters, what are the volunteers to do?
 - What are we at VDS, my "congregation" for this sermon, to do? And how are we to lead in the churches we serve? What can the congregations and communities we're in do, and do better?

- What do we make of the reality that though Mary says the promises of God have been fulfilled, there are individuals living on the streets and impoverished, while some have far more than they need? Are the reversals Mary says happen in God more about a spiritual reality than a material or earthly one? Are they a reminder of the continual faithfulness of God despite hardship? Are they a call to do justice? Are they a promise of future things to come?